

FRONTIER

A card-laying and combination game of nerve, alliances, and the last dollar

Deck	1× American Playing Cards (50 cards)
Excluded Cards	None
Players	2–6
Duration	approx. 20–30 minutes
Complexity	Medium

AT A GLANCE — how a hand wins

VALUE COMBINATIONS Same Value · Run Value worth something	>	NO COMBINATION Mixed Value size can't save it
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Compare two hands top-down — stop at the first line that decides:

1. A **Value Combination** beats **No Combination**.
2. Both combinations → more **Cards** win (5 > 4 > 3).
3. Equal cards → **Same Value** beats **Run Value**.
4. Stronger **Alliance** → Symbol > Color > Border > None.
5. Still level → higher **Total Value** (Cypher = 10).

Cards	Value	Alliance
5	Same Value	Symbol
4	Run Value	Color
3	Mixed Value	Border
2	—	None

Each column runs strongest (top) to weakest (bottom), read on its own. More cards only decides between two combinations (step 2). A lone card (1) forms no Value or Alliance — it counts purely as its own strength.

1. Objective

5 rounds. Everyone starts with \$10 (Standard variant). Each round every player plays a combination of cards and bets money on it; the strongest hand wins the pot. After round 5, whoever holds the most money wins.

2. The Deck

Color	Symbol	Count
Blue	Spades	10
Blue	Clubs	10
Red	Hearts	10
Red	Diamonds	10
Black	Stars	10

Each symbol holds 10 cards: **1 through 9** plus the **Cypher (Ø)**, which counts as 10. **Black (Stars) is neutral** — it can join either Red or Blue, but only as a weaker addition, not a full member (see Section 5).

The Circle. The Cypher links 9 and 1 cyclically — runs may wrap across it (e.g. 8–9–Ø–1 or Ø–1–2). The 1 still counts as 1 in value: the wraparound is a structural advantage, not a value bonus (see Example A).

3. Setup

Shuffle the deck. Each player receives \$10 and draws 1 card — hand size grows by 1 each round (round 5 = 5 cards). The first starting player is chosen at random (e.g. highest card drawn); afterwards the start rotates one seat each round (bankrupt players are skipped).

4. Round Structure

The Market Card. Before the first bet, the top card of the draw pile is turned face up. Any player may voluntarily count it as one of their own cards when forming a combination.

Betting. Each player takes one turn: choose cards (1 up to all), then bet.

- **Open:** the first player bets at least \$1, or folds.
- **Call / Raise:** each following player matches the bet, or raises (at least \$1 more). The last player of the round may only call or fold, not raise.
- **Limit:** no bet may exceed what the poorest active opponent still holds — so they can always call by going all-in.
- **Fold:** no cards, no bet, no claim on the pot.

Showdown. The strongest hand takes the pot (Section 5). Ties split the pot; any odd dollar goes to the first tied player in turn order.

After the round. Played cards are discarded, the deck is reshuffled, and everyone draws up to the new hand size — even players who folded. Anyone at \$0 is eliminated.

Refill (once per game). Before your own bet, you may discard any number of cards and draw the same number of new ones.

5. The Hierarchy

Every hand is read on three axes — **Cards**, **Value**, and **Alliance** — and ranked by the five-step order in the *At a Glance* panel above. This section defines each axis.

Value — the shape of the hand

A **Combination** needs at least 3 cards. There are only two, and either one beats any hand that is not a combination — **whatever the card count** (a 3-card combination beats a 5-card Mixed Value hand).

Value	Meaning
Same Value	3+ cards of the same rank (e.g. three 7s) — the rarer shape, so it outranks a Run
Run Value	3+ cards in sequence (e.g. 4–5–6; the Cypher may close the circle, 9–Ø–1)
Mixed Value	No combination — any 1- or 2-card hand, or 3+ cards that are neither of the above

Alliance — the color discipline (the tiebreak)

Alliance	Meaning
Symbol	All one symbol (e.g. all Spades) — the strongest
Color	All one side (all Red or all Blue), no Black
Border	One side, reinforced with Black (Stars) wildcards
None	Red and Blue both present (a divided hand) — the weakest

Same Value can never reach “Symbol” — each symbol holds every rank only once — so a Same-Value hand’s best possible Alliance is Color.

Cards. Among combinations, more cards win ($5 > 4 > 3$). A single card holds no Value and no Alliance: it counts purely as its own strength.

6. Victory

After round 5, the player with the most money wins (ties are shared). Your closing bankroll is your winnings — carry it straight into the next table.

7. Examples

A — The Circle is no free ride. 9–Ø–1 (using the circle) sums to $9+10+1 = 20$. 8–9–Ø (straight) sums to $8+9+10 = 27$. Both are runs of equal length and Alliance — the straight run wins on total value despite sharing the top card.

B — Formation beats mass. A 3-card Run beats a 5-card Mixed-Value hand. A combination always beats a non-combination, regardless of card count.

C — Rarity wins the standoff. At 3 cards each, three 6s (Same Value) beat a 4–5–6 Run. Equal count → the rarer shape decides.

D — Clean beats big in chaos. Neither hand forms a combination. A 2-card hand of one side plus a Star (Border) beats a 5-card Red-and-Blue hand (None). With no combination made, Alliance outranks sheer size.

E — Color before Border. Two 3-card Runs, both Red. Hearts–Diamonds–Hearts (no Black) is Color and beats Hearts–Stars–Diamonds (Border), despite identical values.

F — The Cypher's quiet rise. Ø–1–2 all of one symbol is a Run at Symbol Alliance — the strongest color there is — even though it holds the deck's lowest card, the 1.

8. FAQ

Why keep betting once I can't catch the leader in round 5? Frontier is a casino game: there isn't only one winner. Anyone who leaves with more money than they brought has won — no matter who is ahead after round 5. The \$10 stake is only the Standard variant; other tables may set different stakes.

Rounds 1 and 2 feel small. True by design. With only 1–2 cards in hand you cannot yet form a 3-card combination, so early rounds are pure skirmishes settled by Alliance and value. The Market Card can already lend a third card, and from round 3 on the real formations arrive.

9. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Value	The shape of a hand: Same Value, Run Value, or Mixed Value
Combination	A Same Value or Run Value hand (3+ cards); always beats a non-combination
Cypher (Ø)	Value 10; closes the circle between 9 and 1
Alliance	A hand's color discipline: Symbol › Color › Border › None
Symbol	The same symbol throughout (e.g. only Spades)
Color	One side (Red or Blue), without Black
Border	One side, reinforced with Black (Stars)
None	Red and Blue both present
Run	3+ cards of consecutive value
Same Value	3+ cards of equal rank
Market Card	Revealed draw card, usable by everyone
Refill	One-time partial hand exchange per game
Pot	All bets gathered in a round

The Freedom of Cards. American Playing Cards was introduced by Simon Allmer on the USA's 250th Independence Day. Frontier is one of many games built for this 5-suit system. Learn more at simonallmer.com/americanplayingcards.